DERECH HASHEM: THE RAMHAL'S WAY OF GOD, AT TIFERET EYAL

What Happens to the Soul When We Sleep?

Derech Hashem 3:1:6

Sefer: Derech Hashem by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Section:** Part 3, Chapter 1, paragraph 6 **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Derech Hashem series at Tiferet Eyal, Thursday 28 October 2021

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Review: two kinds of nefesh

There are two kinds of nefesh. One is the animal nefesh that every mammal has, connected to the blood, which gives us our drives and character traits. The other is the higher nefesh, divided into five parts: nefesh, ruah, neshamah, hayah and yehidah, the lowest being nefesh and the highest yehidah. These five parts are subdued because they are in the body and cannot express themselves. But at certain times we receive an addition, such as the extra soul of Shabbat, which gives a closer ability to connect with that part of our identity. Then a person may have intuition, what the Gemara calls "his mazal saw": something in him perceives what he does not consciously see. The more a person is in touch with his higher soul, the more he has such intuitions.

Why dreams matter

Now the Ramhal turns to dreams. Dreams appear again and again in Sefer Bereshit: Avimelekh's dream, Yaakov's, and soon Yosef's dreams in Vayeshev and Pharaoh's in Mikes, six or seven times in all. "So dreams are not something to be taken lightly." What are they, what is their function, and how do they work?

Paragraph 6: day for work, night for rest

Hashem in His wisdom divided time into two parts, one for activity and one for rest: day and night. As the verse in Tehillim says, man goes out to his work until evening; and the Gemara says that night was created for sleep. (When a participant joked about English winter evenings, the Rabbi told him to move to Israel and live with proper times.)

Hashem placed in the nature of living creatures that they sleep, so that their spirits rest from their labour and renew their strength, both physical and spiritual, and they return fresh in the morning. The Rabbi highlighted this point: sleep is rest not only for the body but for the soul. How the soul rests, we will see.

While a person sleeps, his powers rest and his senses are quiet. They are not switched off: prod a sleeping person and he will feel it. Even his intellect is at rest. That is why the Gemara in

Berakhot says sleep is one-sixtieth of death. One-sixtieth is always the measure for something present but negligible, as in the laws of kashrut, where a forbidden substance that is less than a sixtieth of the mixture is nullified. Sleep is death, but negligible.

Only the imagination keeps working. It forms images from what a person thought about while awake, and from substances reaching the brain from the body or from food. The Rabbi called this a medical explanation: dreams are a product of what you thought, what you ate and what your body releases. "Nothing dramatic here."

The soul's nightly journey

Now the important part. Hashem decreed further that during sleep the higher soul detaches slightly from its physical trappings. Of its five parts, the top four depart and rise to the spiritual world; only the lowest, the nefesh of the neshamah, stays behind with the animal nefesh. (Again, "don't confuse nefesh with nefesh": the animal nefesh always stays.)

The Rabbi connected this to washing hands in the morning. Wherever there is a vacuum of holiness, there is tumah. That is why a dead body has the highest level of tumah: the neshamah has left. In sleep, a sixtieth of death, part of our spiritual identity has left, so there is some impurity, and we wash our hands on waking.

The four parts that rise move about in the spiritual world and have dealings with spiritual agents: positive forces, or destructive ones, according to what they meet. Sometimes what they encountered is transmitted down to the part of the soul that stayed behind, and from there to the imagination and the brain, producing images. The information may be true or false, depending on whom the soul was dealing with: the right malakhim bring true information, destructive forces false. And it often arrives in great distortion and confusion.

Whom the soul connects with depends on who you are, what kind of person you are and what the soul is drawn to. This is why the soul "gets a break" at night: if the neshamah were trapped in the body constantly, it would lose its ability. Every night it gets a respite from the body's confines.

Questions from the group

A participant asked whether a holy person who barely sleeps and learns all the time is not already spiritual. The Rabbi said of course, but the body always traps the soul, even for the greatest saddik, even Moshe Rabbenu. That is why we must die: the soul cannot have full devekut in its current body. However great you are, your soul needs a break from your body, which is why every human being must sleep. The Gemara rules that an oath not to sleep for three days is not valid, since it is impossible. Asked about King David, who is said to have slept only "sixty breaths," the Rabbi said it is not to be taken literally.

Another participant described dreaming about a frightening event from the day, and contrasted Yosef's dream of the sheaves, which he could not have experienced. The Rabbi said a dream is a mix: elements of what you thought during the day, and elements from spiritual agents. That is why the Gemara spends pages on all kinds of strange dreams.

Asked whether one should then sleep twelve hours a day to gain more connection, the Rabbi said no: that is wasting your time; there is a balance. Questions about sleeping pills,

anaesthetic, induced comas and night-shift workers he left open: one would need to find out medically what is happening in the brain.

The next paragraph: dreams that foretell

It is also possible to receive information in a dream about something that is going to happen, when Hashem decides that the soul should know it through one of the good channels. It comes down to the lower soul and to the brain, usually unclearly, but sometimes clearly. As the verse in Iyov says, in dreams and visions of the night Hashem "opens the ears of men." Such information can be good or bad. Sometimes a dream is nonsense, coming from negative forces; sometimes it comes from positive forces and is true.

Next time: how this fits with the Gemara's teaching that dreams follow their interpretation. If a dream is information from Hashem, how can interpreting it change anything?

Summary

- Hashem made night for rest, and sleep rests the soul as well as the body.
- Sleep is one-sixtieth of death: the senses and intellect rest and only the imagination works, partly from the day's thoughts and the body's substances.
- In sleep the top four parts of the higher soul rise and interact with good or destructive spiritual forces, which is why we wash our hands on waking.
- What they encounter may filter down as dreams, true or false, often confused, depending on what the person is drawn to.
- Some dreams carry real information about the future; how this fits "dreams follow their interpretation" is next.

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